Sustainability in Scotland: The Gap Between Ambition and Implementation

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The Implementation Gap

Scotland has positioned itself as one of the more ambitious political bodies in Europe regarding sustainability, particularly through its commitment to achieving net zero emissions by 2045. These climate goals reflect a substantial political and cultural investment in environmental responsibility. However, while these targets appear strong in policy, the practical implementation of sustainability in Scotland reveals a more complicated issue. Through community conversations and academic research, it becomes clear that Scotland's sustainability model exists within the larger political framework of Westminster that limits its full ability to act independently.

A major cause of this tension is devolution. Although Scotland has its own Parliament and authority over various domestic issues such as education and environmental policy, major areas such as energy regulation, defense, foreign affairs, and broader economic systems remain connected to Westminster. Keating (2017) argues that Scottish devolution provides political authority without complete sovereignty, creating structural limits on what Scotland can achieve

on its own. This creates an implementation gap, the divide between sustainability goals and the political power required to achieve said goals (Ellis, 2013; Keating, 2017).

This paper explores how Scotland's political relationship with the United Kingdom impacts sustainability in terms of renewable energy and public trust. By both analyzing academic and non-academic sources along with observations from Bute, Cowal, Dunoon, and the Scottish Parliament, this paper argues that Scotland's sustainability future is heavily shaped by a tension between environmental ambition and incomplete governing authority. At the same time, Scotland's strong local communities often make up for these limitations.

Devolution and Sustainability Governance

Devolution allows Scotland to make decisions in many domestic areas, but its authority is partial. Ellis (2013) mentions that although Scotland can influence planning and environmental frameworks, energy markets and national grid systems are under UK governance. This creates a political structure where Scotland may legislate for sustainability all while lacking full control over the power required to implement it.

This structural limitation became clearer during my visit to the Scottish Parliament. Before visiting, I viewed Parliament largely as a requirement of governance. However, observing the live debates and electronic voting process made governance feel real and operational rather than just theoretical. It became evident that sustainability policy is not only shaped by ambition but by negotiation and political compromise.

This observation aligns with the SPICe Spotlight (2025) analysis of devolution and climate governance, which explains that Scotland often carries climate responsibilities while

working under reserved powers controlled by Westminster. This creates a structural mismatch between accountability and authority. Scotland can set ambitious goals, but the delivery of these goals often depends on a system wherein it does not fully govern.

The Climate Change Committee (2024) reinforces this by repeatedly noting the difference between target-setting and measurable progress. Scotland remains ahead in ambition, but actual implementation continues to fall short.

Renewable Energy's Structural Limits

Renewable energy is one of the clearest examples of Scotland's sustainability ambitions. Scotland produces a significant portion of the United Kingdom's renewable energy, particularly through wind power. During my time in Cowal and Dunoon, the scale of wind infrastructure showed Scotland's commitment to renewable energy. Physically seeing this infrastructure initially gave the impression that Scotland had a strong level of energy independence.

However, after listening to Charles, who showed our group around Cowal, and conducting research, this assumption proved incorrect. Cowell et al. (2017) explain that renewable energy governance in the UK is "rescaled," meaning that while Scotland hosts much of the infrastructure, pricing systems, market regulation, and transmission networks remain controlled at a broader UK level. This means Scotland's energy output does not necessarily translate into independent energy authority.

This limitation is especially visible in the transmission bottleneck discussed by Kemp (2025). Scotland produces significant renewable energy in the north, but a high demand lies in

England. Because transmission capacity remains limited, renewable energy cannot always move south. This restricts more renewable expansion and creates setbacks in new projects.

Aitken (2010) adds to this by arguing that renewable energy must also be understood socially, not just technically. Public support and local cooperation remain important. What stood out during my time in Scotland was that renewable energy appeared less politically divisive than in the United States. Conversations with locals and land managers suggested a wide acceptance of sustainability as a necessity rather than a political identity.

This exposes a major contradiction. Scotland has the public support and policy ambition for renewable leadership. However, incomplete structural authority limits its ability to turn that position into practical progress.

The Ferry Crisis

Transportation is another vital sustainability issue, particularly for island communities. While staying in Bute, I heard conversations about the ferry crisis. Older individuals in a local pub discussed the issue with frustration, emphasizing the financial disruption.

The ferry system is central to island life. It affects access to healthcare, employment, tourism, and food supply. Without stable transport systems, communities become isolated. In this sense, transport is not separate from sustainability but essential to it.

The Week (2024) explains the ongoing ferry crisis, describing years of political mismanagement and increasing costs. Similarly, the Scottish Liberal Democrats (2025) document how ferry issues continue to affect communities in Argyll and Bute.

What stood out during these conversations was the distinction between trust in Scotland as a nation and trust in its government. There was clear pride in Scottish identity, but evident frustration with political systems. The Open Government Partnership (2025) explains that low political trust often develops when institutional promises repeatedly fail to be fulfilled. In Bute, the ferry crisis provided a real example of this.

This suggests that sustainability depends not only on environmental policy but on stable infrastructure. If transportation systems fail, broader sustainability goals become much harder to sustain.

Trust, Political Legitimacy, and Independence

Trust stood out as one of the strongest themes throughout my time in Scotland. Beyond policy, sustainability also depends on whether communities trust the institutions responsible for delivering it.

This became clear in conversations about Scottish independence. During my time in Bute, our group spoke with Reeni about independence and governance. The conversation with Reeni highlighted that hesitation toward independence was more complicated than I had initially assumed. Although there was clear pride in Scotland as a nation, there also seemed to be uncertainty about what full independence would mean in practice. This reflects a disconnect between national identity, political trust, and perhaps questions of long-term stability.

The Pew Research Center (2025) shows similarly declining trust in government in the United States, suggesting this is not unique to Scotland. However, in Scotland, this distrust exists alongside a strong local trust in communities. This distinction is key. People may distrust

political systems while still having faith in community sustainability. This creates a central tension wherein local trust remains strong and institutional trust appears fragile.

Community as a Sustainability Response

Despite structural limitations, Scotland's strongest sustainability resource may be its communities themselves. Throughout my trip, local stewardship repeatedly appeared as a major source of strength.

At Bridgend Farm, sustainability was visible not just through environmental practices but through social organization. The farm functioned as a communal space with workshops and local engagement. This reflected Neil McInroy's (2025) argument that Scotland is increasingly shifting toward community wealth-building, where economic value is retained locally rather than moving upward into larger systems.

This idea became even clearer in Bute and Cowal. Through conversations with Amy, Mary-Lou, Charles, and Reeni, who guided our group during the trip, it became clear that sustainability was mostly discussed as intergenerational responsibility. Amy spoke directly about involving younger people in land stewardship so that environmental responsibility could continue into the future. This reflects a broader Scottish approach to sustainability, one that focuses not only on protecting the environment, but on continuing that responsibility for future generations.

Charles also discussed the economic changes in Cowal and Dunoon, specifically the decline of pubs, hotels, and fishing-based economies. However, rather than abandoning the land

due to these losses, there has been an effort to rebuild in ways more aligned with environmental and community sustainability. This bottom-up approach is one of Scotland's strongest assets.

Conclusion

Scotland presents a unique model of sustainability because it combines strong environmental ambition with structural political limitations. Its devolved system allows it to set major climate targets and cultivate community-based sustainability practices. However, it remains constrained by Westminster in critical areas such as energy regulation and economic authority, while its own transport failures, such as the ferry crisis, have weakened public trust.

This creates an implementation gap between ambition and delivery. This gap becomes clear in areas such as renewable energy and transportation, but also in the way people speak about government. At the same time, Scotland's communities demonstrate an alternative source of sustainability strength. Through intergenerational responsibility and community-centered efforts, sustainability appears to continue even where governance falls short.

What stood out most throughout this trip was that sustainability in Scotland felt less politicized than in the United States. Whether speaking to farmers, land managers, pub-goers, or local guides, there was often a shared understanding that land must be worked with rather than against.

This paper ultimately argues that Scotland's sustainability future depends on whether political authority can become better aligned with environmental ambition. Scotland has the ideas and the community foundation. The question is whether Scotland's government has enough power to fully support the future it wants to create.

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